The little gecko

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The little gecko

by the_deaf_pomegranate

Summary

A gift for EmileeDoodles for this solstice, a fic inspired by her Catradora Etheria travel calendar!

Catra and Adora are finally travelling the world together, but they're yet to discover that they've brought a little friend along for the ride...

"I just can't get my head around it," Adora exclaims, her palms spreading across their travel binder's dappled leather cover, "Can you believe this time next year, we will have been to so many places together? Seen so many things? And tried all those different foods? Catra, it's… it's…"

Adora's cheeks redden as she realises she's getting a little overexcited, taking a deep breath to slow her roll. Catra smirks, her tail flicking back and forth with amusement.

"Carry on, princess, don't mind me."

"Well," Adora says, looking down a little bashfully, "Leaving everything behind and doing this with you. It's kind of all I ever wanted."

Notes

Happy New Year to the lovely Emilee Doodles! I know you were a little miffed that organising the Flex solstice swap left you without any gifts, so I thought I would surprise you! Hope you like this little fluff fic inspired by your work and that it heals your FOMO feels ❤️

FYI this is 10000% the fluffiest, non-angsty thing I've ever written (and will likely ever write) so please enjoy it while it lasts ;)

See the end of the work for more notes

It’s only taken two weeks, but they’ve finally figured everything out. In true Adora style, the dining table is covered in maps and tourist guides, pins and strings tracing the route that’ll take them around Etheria. If it weren’t for Catra’s handwritten notes - concise and compiled into a single binder - Adora isn’t sure they’d ever have gotten to this point. And now, there’s only a few days of work left until their departure day.

“I just can’t get my head around it,” Adora exclaims, her palms spreading across the binder’s dappled leather cover, “Can you believe that this time next year, we will have been to so many places together? Seen so many things? And tried all those different foods? Catra, it’s… it’s…”

Adora’s cheeks redden as she realises she’s getting a little overexcited, taking a deep breath to slow her roll. Catra smirks, her tail flicking back and forth with amusement.

“Carry on, princess, don’t mind me.”

“Well,” Adora says, looking down a little bashfully, “Leaving everything behind and doing this with you. It’s kind of all I ever wanted.”

When she feels Catra’s hand rest on top of hers, Adora knows what her girlfriend’s going to say before she voices it.

“Me too,” Catra’s speaks gently, her thumb rubbing circles into the back of Adora’s hand, “It’s been a long time coming, huh?”

Adora leans into Catra’s space, twisting awkwardly in her seat to kiss her. Her thigh digs painfully into the wooden arm of her chair as she moves but it’s worth it when Catra’s scent engulfs her and the soft pressure of her lips spreads warmth through Adora’s chest. Most days, she takes this a little for granted. It seems like they live on a completely different planet since they were separated by war and resentment, or since they had to figure out who they were without the pressure of conflict or a new high-stakes relationship. Yet when Adora feels pride sparking at the

achievement of ticking off this lifelong goal - one that's been buried deep in her mind since Catra had slept curled at the foot of her cadet bunk - it astounds her that they've actually got here.

"Hey, dummy," Catra's voice rolls over Adora's skin, her breath gliding over Adora's lips like so many times before, "You ready to write a packing list next?"

Boy, is Adora ready.

Adora's pretty sure they're all set to leave.

She steps into the middle of the skiff and surveys her work, running a mental checklist to ensure they haven't forgotten anything. From the graffiti Catra's carved on the vehicle to the rust-red bedding that's made the cabin into a cosy fort, Adora's confident that this is the place they'll make plenty of unforgettable memories.

The excitement makes Adora's heart drum a little faster, anticipation thrumming in her veins. She can practically feel She-Ra's power simmering inside her, though for once it isn't fuelled by adrenaline on a mission. She leans forward to the front of the skiff and reaches out for the ignition levers - the engine comes to life, a rumbling vibration joining the ripple that already runs through her body.

"Hey, Adora!" She whips around to find Catra dragging a square wooden chest out of their home, Melog nudging it forward with their nose, "Think you're forgetting something?"

"Huh? We've got everything on the list, Cat." Adora cocks her head in confusion, her brain scrambling to think of what she'd possibly forgotten. The last thing she wants is to remember

something and have to turn back once they've gotten to the Whispering Woods.

"Don't you kinda need *me* for this trip around the world with the love of your life?" Catra raises an eyebrow and lets go of the chest with a thud as she crosses her arms, a smirk taking over her face.

Adora laughs, switching off the engine and vaulting over the edge of the skiff to gather Catra up in her arms. "You make a good point!"

"I usually do."

Catra's smug and Adora wants to kiss the satisfaction off her face. She scoffs instead, knowing the power play of withholding kisses is only going to lead to more fun later if Catra gets wound up. Still, it isn't lost on Adora that the tingling below her gut isn't that secretive when She-Ra starts to emerge; carrying Catra onto the skiff is a lot easier when its walls don't come much higher than mid-calf. Catra squeezes Adora's widened bicep, and it's enough to know her little tease has done its job. She tosses Catra onto the pillows in the fort and kneels in front of her, fingers twitching when she sees Catra's tooth bite down on her bottom lip.

"You should grab that chest for me before we start this," Catra says breathlessly, her chest rising and falling a little too heavily for the daymoon, "We'll never get going otherwise."

"What's in it?" Adora asks, "You didn't put anything else on the list."

Catra smiles, stretching out her foot so it runs along the outside of Adora's thigh, "That's for me to know and for you to ponder."

"Just ponder?" Adora wheedles, crawling up Catra's legs until she has her pinned down at the hips.

"I don't get the impression you'll have any problem pondering, princess." Catra runs an open hand along the route her foot took,

her thumb inching dangerously close to the apex of Adora's thighs before she slaps her on the hip and pushes Adora off her. "Go on. Get it."

Adora blushes hard and rolls off the makeshift bed, retreating to fetch Catra's chest. She's no idea what trick Catra has up her sleeve, but by the time she's lugged the damn thing onboard and dumped it under the photos she's painstakingly pinned to the external wall of the cabin, Adora's so obviously consumed by curiosity that Melog jumps on top of the chest protectively. Catra crawls out of bed and leans on the doorpost lazily. Adora doesn't miss that she seems to be wearing significantly less of her outfit than a couple of minutes ago.

"Well? Are we ready for take-off?" Catra's eyes glisten with mischief.

Adora laughs, shrinking into her normal form and pressing the auto-navigate button. The skiff starts to rise off the ground and Adora's never been more grateful to Catra for insisting they let Entrapta add extra functions, not to mention that she'd barred Glimmer and Bow from seeing them off.

"Let the adventures begin!" Adora can't contain her excitement, her voice ringing out loudly.

She rushes to Catra and plants kisses all up the side of her neck as they begin to move, swallowing the giggles it elicits with her lips when Catra wraps her legs around Adora's thighs and hoists herself up onto her hips. This time, Adora gets to stay in the fort when she lays Catra down and it's only when the stars come out that they join Melog outdoors.

Every day of their trip so far, Catra demands an hour of privacy and makes Adora shut her eyes as she gathers items from her

chest to sneak in and out of the cabin. Despite Adora's whining - or, let's be honest, outright begging - Catra won't spill a single word about what she's up to.

Sometimes when she has this time alone, Adora hums under her breath and it's only when Catra's tail thumps from afar that Adora realises she can be heard at all. Today, she hasn't bothered to quieten at all, her voice carrying over lush trees and fields of produce.

Catra emerges from the cabin and nuzzles into her back, wrapping her arms around Adora's waist. From time to time, Catra twists around a little, her ears moving as she picks up something from a new direction. Adora is so used to not hearing what Catra does that she's surprised when her girlfriend says anything at all.

"You've got a companion," Catra muses, her chin shifting behind Adora's shoulder.

"Hmm?" Adora has no idea what she's getting at, even more so than usual. She hasn't noticed anything but her own voice carrying in the wind.

"Oh, don't worry," Catra says after a beat, "It's stopped now."

Adora feels so blissful she doesn't bother pressing for extra info. She's always needed to know everything at all times to feel safe and in control, but only a few weeks into their trip, Adora doesn't feel the same urgency as usual. She's perfectly content to melt into Catra's hold instead, taking in the vista surrounding them.

"It's so fucking pink," Catra grumbles as she peers over the bow of the skiff and tucks herself under Adora's arm, mere metres from landing in the plains of Plumeria.

"Your favourite colour is red," Adora points out, prodding Catra playfully, "That's like basically extra pink pink."

"Whatever," Catra rolls her eyes, but the grin on her face tells Adora she's not really annoyed about anything, "It'll be nice to see

Scorp and ‘Fuma anyway.”

Adora squeezes Catra fondly. “Don’t pretend this isn’t the bit you’ve been most excited about. I know you’ve been counting down the seconds until you get to see Scorpia.”

“Hmmm…” Catra’s voice lilts at the end, her tail wrapping around Adora’s wrist, “I don’t remember consenting to such defamation when I agreed to travel with you.”

Adora doesn’t reply to Catra’s tease, simply pressing a kiss to her cheek as they begin to land. Just as she predicted, Catra’s the first to run off the skiff at the first sight of her friend, leaving Adora for dust before they’ve even touched the ground. There’s something that flashes and jumps out the corner of her eye, but when Adora spins around to see it properly, she’s sure it was just a figment of her imagination.

Probably just steering fatigue… A few nights’ good sleep in Plumeria will make all the difference!

When Adora finally disembarks from the skiff, Melog leaps off with her to roll around in the thick Plumerian grass. Adora embraces Perfuma warmly when she reaches her, thanking her for the flower crown the princess bequeaths her.

“You wouldn’t believe how much Scorpia’s been going on about this,” Perfuma says when they turn to watch their partners chattering ahead of them, “We’ve hardly talked about anything but your visit for weeks!”

“Believe me,” Adora grins, her chest warming at the sight of Catra enjoying Scorpia’s company so freely, “I know.”

“Can you hear anything weird?” Adora murmurs as they glide further away from Thaymore, her belly rounded from the feast of delicacies she devoured at their farewell gathering.

There’s a chirping, clicking noise that’s been seeping into the air for the past couple of hours. Usually sounds of nature don’t annoy her at all. Still, when she’s this bloated and she can’t imagine ever being able to move again, being haunted by something (or someone) unknown is almost making Adora's skin crawl.

“You haven’t noticed it yet?” Catra glances over her shoulder at Adora laid out on the skiff floor from her spot at the steering rod, “That thing’s been with us since we left home.”

“What?” Adora cranes her neck to see Catra better, “You serious?”

“Dude! She put on a performance when we were in Elberon. You didn’t notice her when we were making out against that tree?”

“We made out against a lot of trees during our week there…” Adora whines, her bottom lip sticking out in a pout. She doesn’t like forgetting specific make out sessions.

“Well, it was the tree right after you brought She-Ra out. When we needed that break from everyone else during the solstice party?”

“Oh,” Adora’s skin flushes from the bottom of her sternum to her apples of her cheeks, “That time *was* pretty memorable. I didn’t realise we had an audience.”

Catra chuckles, her ears perking high and facing forwards, “I don’t think that would have stopped you. You were… *ahem*. Rather single-minded.”

Adora squeezes her fists at the memory. That night, she’d hardly been able to keep her hands off Catra. She’d decided then and there exactly how she was going to propose when they got home from their trip, after she’d noticed a local diplomat’s brooch fastened to his boyfriend’s suit lapel. She hadn’t been able to

decide on a token that would encapsulate all of her feelings to be worthy of giving to Catra before then. But in an instant, it occurred to her. The winged pin she'd received upon joining the Rebellion was perfect. Not only would it bring out the gold of Catra's left eye beautifully, but if heroism had been both her biggest honour and burden, this pin could represent her willingness to share all the positives and negatives of life with her partner. And perhaps, if Catra wanted to, she'd have something significant to give Adora too.

"Can you put auto-pilot on?" Adora asks, her hands unfurling. She's itching to feel Catra again now she's been reminded of her plan.

"Ha, Adora, you can hardly move! Besides we'll be at the Crystal Castle soon."

Adora sighs, realising Catra's far more right than she wants her to be. Driving on auto-pilot has served them well. Landing, on the other hand, wasn't their forte and they had enough unintended bruises to prove it.

"Can you lie next to me, then? Just for five minutes?"

She can hear Catra humming as she weighs up her decision. "Okay, princess."

The second Catra's weight settles next to her, Adora takes her hand right away. It's cooler than she expected, though she supposes it's colder when you're standing and exposed to the night sky instead of warmed by the skiff engine under the floor. The chirping only gets louder as auto-pilot mode slows the skiff, decelerating from Catra's preferred (completely reckless, in Adora's opinion) driving speed.

"It's a gecko, by the way," Catra offers, dragging her free fingers up and down Adora's forearm therapeutically, "Good sign, huh?"

"Good sign?" Adora muses aloud. All she knows about geckos is that they're reptiles, and she's far more familiar with horses than

those.

“The First Ones thought geckos represented the spirits of their ancestors, and that they’re sacred guardians of the home," Catra says with unexpected surety, “So she’s probably protecting us.”

“They did?” Adora has no idea how Catra could know this. Neither of them has ever studied the mythology of the First Ones - they’ve been far too tied up in diplomatic business and have only tried to investigate the Magicat legends of Halfmoon in their spare time.

Catra’s cringing with her eyes squeezed shut when Adora rolls onto her side with difficulty and props herself up with one arm.

“How do you know that?” Adora traces Catra’s cheek gently until she peeks out one eye and looks at her.

“I guess I may as well fess up now,” Catra exhales, her line of sight flitting back to the stars, “I was only going to tell you in the morning anyway.”

Adora waits for Catra to continue but she doesn’t say anything else. Instead, she gets to her feet and makes a beeline for her wooden chest. Adora clamps her eyes shut out of habit as she moves to sit upright; she can hear Catra chuckle ahead of her.

“It’s not a secret now, dummy. Open your eyes.”

Adora rubs her brow and acquiesces, finding Catra smiling nervously at her. She’s laid out several books between them, all written in First Ones language. They’re a mix of folklore and fairytale anthologies, along with guidebooks on linguistics and history annals - not that Catra could possibly know that. No one else can read them.

“I don’t do therapy twice a week.” Catra admits after a beat, “I haven’t in, like, two years.”

“Catra!” Adora admonishes, her jaw dropping, “Why would you-”

“Relax,” Catra interrupts her, darting out to place a reassuring hand on her leg, “I still had weekly sessions! But I spent the second hour taking lessons with Lance and George instead. That’s what I do when I’m in the cabin everyday. Tuesdays, I call them on the trackerpad, and the other days I’m doing my homework. I figured out they have quite a few things wrong though, I’m pretty sure I’ve got a better grasp of the vocab now than they do-”

“Vocab?” Adora’s leaning forward now as she cuts Catra’s rambling off to echo what she’s heard, her eyes flitting between Catra’s trepid expression and the book covers.

“I wanted to do this for you,” Catra speaks softly, her voice quieter than usual, “I can read First Ones now, Adora. When we get to the Crystal Castle, it won’t all be on you to navigate.”

Adora’s breath catches in her lungs. She never expected anything like this. Her lack of response clearly concerns Catra. Before she has a chance to say anything, her girlfriend’s already rushing to fill in the silence.

“I started when we were trying to find out if Halfmoon still exists. It wasn’t just for this trip! I just… You worked so hard to help me figure out my history. I wanted to support you exploring yours too!”

“But we never found Halfmoon,” Adora replies, dazed by the revelation, “It isn’t in our itinerary or anything.”

“It was never about whether we were successful, ‘Dor,” Catra’s grip on her thigh tightens as she speaks, “It was that you tried.”

“So. This is you trying?” Adora cups Catra’s jaw, the uncomfortable fullness in her belly suddenly forgotten. It’s unreal, the idea that she isn’t alone in reading such texts now; that Catra cared enough to make sure she wasn’t alone in anything.

“Yeah, I guess,” Catra smiles nervously, “If that’s okay?”

“It’s incredible,” Adora leans forward over the books to meet her lips, “You’re incredible.”

“I’ve been told that before,” Catra smirks, pecking her back, “I’m glad you think so.”

Adora smiles so widely that the crinkles at the edges of her eyes hurt. Despite the whirr of the gecko’s chitter in the background, it takes everything not to offer her pin to Catra that very second.

“Tell me more,” Adora whispers into Catra’s ear when she’s done nibbling on her lobe, her body warm and languid from their colourful Salinean cocktails, “It’s so hot when you talk First Ones.”

“You mean when I tell you facts about geckos?” Catra dissolves into a snicker, her little shrieks shaking her shoulders, “You wanna hear that their eyes are three-hundred-and-fifty times more sensitive to light than yours?”

“That’s a really good fact,” Adora mumbles, snaking her hand around Catra’s neck to scratch her nape where she knows Catra likes, “You got another one?”

“Oh,” Catra groans under her breath, her foot rubbing against Adora’s calf under the table, “Most geckos can detach their tails and grow new ones.”

“Shit. That is very, very cool.” Adora leans away for the briefest second to steal a sip of Catra’s drink but she doesn’t even get her wrist slapped, “You think you could regrow your tail?”

“I dunno but I don’t plan on trying,” Catra prods her squarely in the chest, “So don’t get any kinky ideas, okay?”

“All my ideas about you are kinky, Cat.” Adora retorts, though they both collapse into giggles.

“Alright!” They’re both suddenly interrupted by a booming voice, and when they look away from one another, Mermista’s standing in front of their table, a steaming plate of fries in her hands, “I know you guys are, like, off work and in love, or whatever. But this is some nasty nerd shit and I don’t want it in my kingdom.”

“Mermyyyy,” Adora whines, “Don’t ruin it, we’re having fun!”

“Have fries instead and sober up,” Mermista slams the plate down on the table, marching back to the bar to shove herself between Sea Hawk and a patron he’s clearly annoyed a little too much, “You can carry on with the rest when you're, like, alone.”

Adora shrugs as Catra titters, reaching out to loftily dunk a handful of chips in ketchup and mayo.

“Hey, Cat,” Adora garbles while stuffing her face, her mouth impressively full, “Do you think if we do this again tomorrow, we’ll get more free food?”

“Maybe,” Catra answers, stealing a chip out of Adora’s hand and popping it in her mouth, “But I’m up for torturing Merms either way.”

The desert wind whips around their ears, and Adora’s sure Catra likes being in the Crimson Waste more than she lets on. She watches as Catra breathes in and out with satisfaction, her eyes closing under the gaze of the burning orange sun. The soft chirping and clicking that’s accompanied them everywhere continues to fill in the silence between their conversations, somehow even louder in the wilderness.

“She’s much louder here than in Mystacor,” Adora observes, “Do you think it means she likes it more?”

Catra keeps her eyes closed but she reaches out for Adora’s waist, wrapping her arms around her and laying her head sideways on the curve of Adora’s shoulder.

“You mean our little gecko?”

“Yeah.”

“Maybe she’s getting ready to say hi to us now,” Catra suggests, and Melog glows a little brighter at the thought, “She’s been hiding for a long time.”

Adora reflects back on the previous eight months. It’s simultaneously wonderful and horrifying to think they’ve made it through so many destinations already, and that they’re only four months away from going home. She’s already starting to wonder what might happen to their little friend once their travels are over, if she doesn’t show herself at all. Both her and Catra have hunted all over the skiff to see if they can spot the reptile, but she always evades their sight. It’s certainly annoyed Catra enough - she’s always been adamant she could catch anything - but she doesn’t complain when Adora offers a massage to calm her down afterwards.

There’s not much else for them to say about it, but there’s comfort in focusing on the gecko’s voice as she whistles around them, following every step they take towards the sun.

—

“Are you sure you’re good?” Adora says as she takes Catra’s hand in hers, checking out her outfit choice.

Catra's put on her cut-out leggings and a dark red vest (the one with the boob window that often seeps into Adora's daydreams), and it's only when Catra asks the same question back that Adora realises she's also wearing her old wartime uniform. It turns out they're both creatures of habit at heart, and returning to the Fright Zone comes with a lot of habits to manage.

They clamber hand in hand into the looming metal fortress, Melog wrapping around Catra's legs whenever they pause to peer in a room. The gecko's chitters echo against the rusting walls, amplified by the hard unfriendly surfaces. Her presence has become comforting now, and Adora doesn't even get frustrated by their inability to find her.

By the time they reach the roof, both the gecko and Melog have seemingly left them alone. Catra and Adora look out over the sprawling former Fright Zone and the Scorpion Kingdom's reconstructive efforts, taking in the luscious plants and topiary that's swallowed most of its exteriors. It's sobering after so many years of avoiding this place and only meeting their friends in other cities and towns; even though the war ended so long ago, Catra and Adora are the only former Rebellion members who have yet to visit the site of their childhood.

"When we used to come up here, I used to dream about telling you the truth," Catra says out of the blue, "It's weird not knowing what could have happened if I'd admitted it."

Adora steps behind Catra and circles her waist with her arms, making room for Catra to fall backwards against her chest and be held.

"If I'd told you I loved you, do you think you'd have stayed?" Catra's voice is so small, smaller than Adora's heard it in years, "Or if I'd been honest about how scared I was? Of everything?"

Adora gulps. She wishes she could give the answer Catra wants to hear.

“I don’t know if I’d have stayed,” she admits, pressing her lips to Catra’s hair, “But I’m sure I wouldn’t have taken no for an answer when I asked you to come with.”

Catra nods, turning in Adora’s arms and craning her face upwards. They gaze into each other's eyes for a long minute; neither of them need to share their apologies for any of it anymore. Knowing they’re exactly where they’re supposed to be has been a much better healer than time.

It’s sweeter than ever to kiss in the one place it had been most forbidden; to feel happiness like this in the graveyard of their youth. Adora thinks she could spend the rest of her life in the Fright Zone if she had to now, as long as she had Catra beside her to rewrite the history that had carved its terrible marks on them.

“I love you, Catra,” Adora focuses singularly on Catra’s irises again, determined to be understood as fully and deeply as possible, “Everywhere we go feels like it could be home with you there.”

Catra’s pupils sparkle, but she doesn’t have time to reply before they’re rudely interrupted.

“I love this little gal!” Entrapta shouts from behind them, suddenly having popped up out of nowhere, “Why didn’t you tell me you had a pet gecko? She’s so tiny! Can I call her Lizzy? It’s ironic because geckos *are* lizards, though they’re not like most lizards, and a disproportionately high number of pet lizards are actually called Lizzy!”

“Wait, what?” Catra double takes, her eyes widening as she swings around to get eyes on Entrapta, who’s still cackling at her self-rewarded genius, “Did you see her? Where is she?”

“Oh,” Entrapta’s pigtails whip in the air while she searches her surroundings, “She was right here, but it transpires she is no longer with me. Such a shame - according to leading research in the Etherian Reptilian Anthology, the colour of her skin is very

statistically unusual. I would have loved to examine her more thoroughly!”

Adora’s jaw drops open as they watch Entrapta sidle away - as soon as she’s out of sight, the gecko’s chirping starts all over again.

“Are you kidding me?” Catra lets her forehead fall onto Adora’s chest, “She’s just fucking with us now, right?”

Adora doesn’t do anything but throw her head back and laugh. However disgruntled Catra is by Lizzy’s disappearance, Adora doesn’t think she’s ever felt this content in the Fright Zone before.

It’s wild to think they’re finally homebound but they’re only minutes away from Bright Moon.

They’ve ticked off all the spots on their initial route along with some extra detours: the Whispering Woods, Plumeria, Elberon, Thaymor, the Crystal Castle, Salinas, Mystacor, the Crimson Waste, Erelandia, the Fright Zone and the Northern Reach. It was so different revisiting these places for fun instead of duty, and rewriting memories of when she and Catra had been on opposite sides of the battlefield. There’s a lot to be gained, Adora decides, from seeing things anew when someone you love holds your hand.

Adora’s heart starts to speed up a little at the thought of how Catra’s fingers intertwine with her own so instinctively. Every morning, she wakes with some form of touch between them - a hand around her waist, or a calf slotted between her own. Adora’s determined to have this forever; to reciprocate Catra’s love to her forever.

When we’re home, I’ll find a way to ask.

Her pin almost burns under her palm when she clutches at it in her pocket, nervous heat warming her hand. She turns it over, her thumb sliding over smooth gold and pressing into the worn valleys of its grooves. Adora doesn't want to wear it anymore - it doesn't feel like it belongs to her now. If she's really honest with herself, she's been holding out for a long time to see what it looks like on Catra.

She glances over her shoulder as she steers the skiff. Catra's curled up with Melog against her wooden chest, her eyes focused intensely on a First Ones storybook. They've read this one together in bed a few times. It's for kids, really, but after a lifetime without them, it's nice to indulge in fairytales. Sometimes, Adora can't help but think they're living in one.

The purple cliffs of Bright Moon appear on the horizon and a chuckle tickles at Adora's throat, spreading into a full laugh.

"Look!" Catra's chin lifts at the sound of Adora's voice, "We're so close."

"What are you so excited about?" Catra teases, putting her book away and getting to her feet, "You don't wanna spend any more time alone with me?"

"No, I-"

CHIRP!

Adora's interrupted by the loudest noise they've heard from the gecko yet. She'd all but given up on finding her since the Fright Zone, but she can tell Catra's still been obsessed with hunting her down even if she attempts to do it secretly.

"Oh my God," Catra's so excited her eyes are practically sparkling, "She's here! Put the autopilot on!"

Adora knows auto-pilot is a terrible idea this close to Bright Moon. Yet Catra's so enraptured by the idea of finally finding the gecko that she complies without a second thought. Before she knows it,

they’re racing around the skiff, following Catra’s keen hearing to track the gecko down.

They’re about to give up hope - Adora’s got one eye on Catra’s wilting ears and another on Bright Moon Castle on the horizon - when Melog begins to purr. They both turn swiftly to look at them and there Lizzy is, perched atop Melog’s head. Her skin is a mix of silver, purple and pink, and Adora doesn’t think she’s ever seen a reptile like this before.

“Wow,” Catra exhales in awe, sinking to her knees in front of Melog and the tiny creature, “I can’t believe we found you, buddy. I mean… Fuck.”

Adora crouches next to Catra, noticing that her hands have begun to tremble. Even Melog has started to glow a nervous blue.

“Cat? Is everything alright?”

Catra takes the deepest breath. “Yeah, it’s just… I told myself… and I didn’t think we’d ever find her…”

“What is it?” Adora reaches out for Catra’s hand to help steady it, “You can tell me.”

Catra turns her head, searching Adora’s eyes for something. “I… I told myself if we found her that I’d ask you.”

Adora cocks her head in question. *Ask me?*

“Can I wear your pin?” Adora hasn’t heard Catra speak quite this nervously since they activated the failsafe and sought out the Heart, “And maybe you could keep my mask?”

All of a sudden, Adora’s head swims. She hasn’t had a chance to figure out how to propose perfectly to Catra at all yet - and she was fully expecting to have to teach Catra about the practice of swapping valuable tokens in the first place - yet now she’s the one being proposed to?

“Are you asking…?” Adora’s voice is dazed.

“Will you marry me, Adora?” Catra clutches harder at Adora’s hand and her heart beats so hard that Adora can practically hear it.

“I wanted to ask *you* when we got home,” Adora blurts out, “We’re so close to Bright Moon. Can’t you wait a few more minutes?”

“Nope,” Catra smirks, popping the ‘p’, and Adora’s heart rate accelerates to keep up with hers, “You’re always home when you’re with me. Right?”

It seems so obvious when Catra says it; Adora’s always felt like she’s exactly where she’s supposed to be with Catra there, even when they were enemies. It didn’t matter where on Etheria they actually were. She nods fervently, pulling the pin out of her pocket.

“At least let me ask you, even if you beat me to it.”

“If you must.” Catra’s whispering, but the smile spreading across her face is louder than anything she could say.

“I love you more than anything, Catra. Will *you* marry *me* ?”

“Yeah,” Catra grins, tugging at her vest so Adora can secure her pin in the black fabric, “You bet I will, ‘Dor.”

Adora giggles, her laughter only stifled when Catra leans forward and knocks her onto her back, straddling Adora’s hips before she dips down to kiss her. All Adora can see is Catra, and all she can hear is the gentle chirrups of the gecko.

She’d believed when Catra agreed to go on this trip with her last year that it was impossible to be any happier. But now Adora feels so much joy and so much hope stretching ahead of her and Catra, it’s ludicrous she thought their journey was coming to an end today.

Thanks to their little gecko friend, today is truly only the start.

End Notes

kudos and comments always appreciated ❤ please feed my ego ❤

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